

ART AND CULTURE



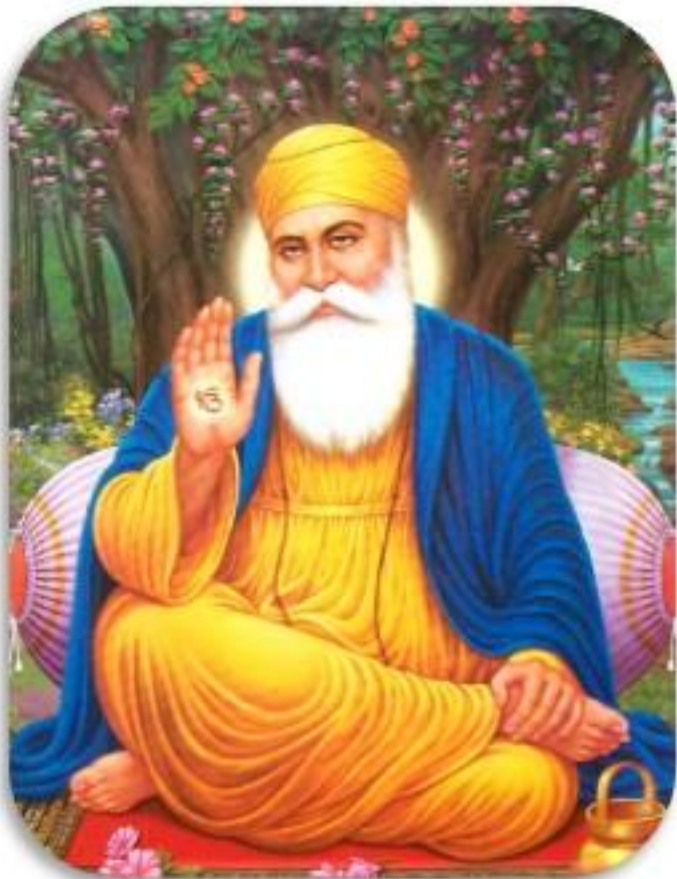
RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

IMPORTANT RELIGIONS IN INDIA

MODULE – 12



SIKHISM



- 1 Amongst the major religions of the world, Sikhism is the one of the youngest and only 500 years old.
- 2 It originated in the Punjab region in the **teachings of Guru Nanak** (in the 15th century CE) and in that of the subsequent other nine Gurus.
- 3 Today, it has more than 25 million followers the world over.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

SIKHISM

FAITH & FUNDAMENTAL BELIEFS

- 1** The fundamental beliefs of Sikhism articulated in the sacred scripture Guru Granth Sahib include
- faith and **meditation** on the name of the one creator,
 - divine unity and **equality** of all human,
 - engaging in selfless service,
 - striving for **justice** for the benefit and prosperity of all, and
 - **honest conduct and livelihood** while living a householder's life.

- 2** Sikhism is a **monotheistic religion** which believes in one God. Here the **world is considered to be a reflection of the creator** and hence, not an entity separate from it.

- 3** Thus, God is omnipresent (**Sarv Vyapak**), infinite, and is signified by **Ik-Onkar** which represents the divine melody of the one Supreme Being.



Ik Onkar is the symbol that represents the one supreme reality and is a central tenet of Sikh religious philosophy.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

SIKHISM

FAITH & FUNDAMENTAL BELIEFS

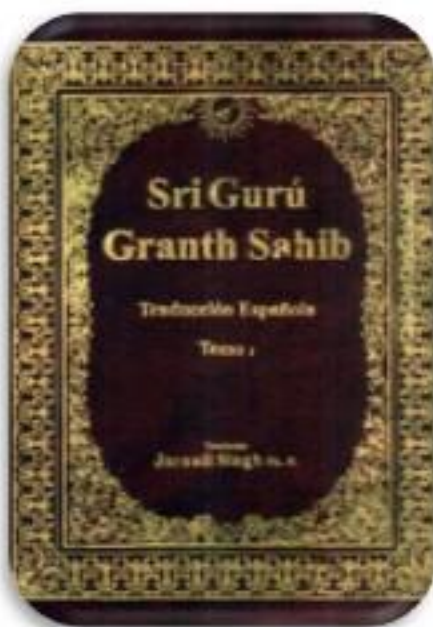
- 4 It considers God to be **Sat** (or truth), **Sat Guru** (true guru), **Kartar** (creator), **Nirankar** (without form), **Akal Purkh** (timeless being), and **Wahe Guru** (praise to guru).
- 5 Sikhism emphasises on **realization of truth as the highest ideal**.
- 6 But it does not prescribe the path of **ascetism and self mortification** for this.
- 7 It professes one to be **Gurmukh** (or God conscious) and to follow the path of **Japa** (recitation of the name of God), **Kirtana** (devotional prayer), and **Naam-Simran** (singing the names of God).
- 8 It also emphasizes on humans to be wary of the **five thieves** in the path of salvation which are **ego, anger, greed, attachment, and lust**.



Satnam Waheguru

SIKHISM

SCRIPTURES IN SIKHISM



1 Sri Guru Granth Sahib or the Adi Granth is the Holy Book of the Sikhs.

2 It is considered as the supreme spiritual authority and head of the Sikh religion. It lays down moral and ethical rules for development of the soul, spiritual salvation and unity with God.

3 It comprises 3384 verses composed by the 10 Sikh gurus and many other saints of the Bhakti period such as Kabir, Namdev, Ramanand, Pipa, Ravidas, Sheikh Farid, and others.

4 Guru Nanak (the first guru) contributed 974 hymns while guru Arjan Dev contributed 2218 hymns.

5 The Tenth Guru, Guru Gobind Singh, named the Sikh scripture Guru Granth Sahib as his successor, terminating the line of human Gurus and making the scripture the eternal, religious spiritual guide for Sikhs.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

SIKHISM

THE KHALSA



- 1 Although the initial development of Sikhism was influenced by the devotion to God and the Bhakti movement, the persecution of Guru Arjan and Guru Teg Bahadur at the hands of Mughal Emperors (Jahangir and Aurangzeb) led to the birth of a military order within Sikhism.
- 2 The Khalsa, literally meaning the pure, was introduced by Guru Gobind Singh (the tenth and the last Guru) as the Sant-Sipahi (a saint soldier) to protect the freedom of conscience and religion.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

SIKHISM

THE KHALSA



Five 'K's of Sikhism

- 3 The Sikhs who were not initiated into the Khalsa were called as **Sahajdhari Sikhs**.
- 4 The baptized Sikhs were called '**Singh**' and the women were called '**Kaur**'.
- 5 It exhorted its followers to wear the five symbols of **kesh**, **kangha** (comb), **kada** (steel bracelet), **kaccha** (short drawers), and **kirpan** (sword).
- 6 This kind of differentiation at a very physical level gave uniformity to the movement and made them different than their co-religionists.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

SIKHISM

THE KHANDA



1 The Khanda is the symbol of the Sikh faith, that attained its current form around the first decade of the 20th century.

2 It is an amalgam of three symbols:

- A **double-edged khanda** (sword) in the centre
- A **chakkar** (chakram)
- **Two single-edged swords**, or kirpan, crossed at the bottom, which sit on either side of the khanda and chakkar.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

SIKHISM

THE KHANDA

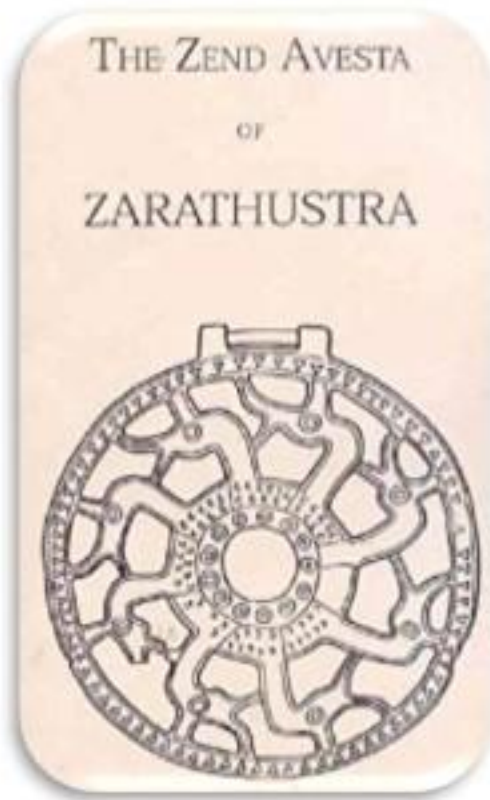


3 Guru Hargobind was the first one to grid the two swords as the symbol for Sikhs, which symbolized the spiritual (piri) and temporal (miri) authority and represented the combination of the **Bhakti and Shakti**.

4 He constructed the **Akal Takht and Lohagrah fort** as markers of his authority, to conduct daily business and defence.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

ZOROASTRIANISM



- 1 The faith of Zoroastrianism had its origin in **Persia in the teachings of Zoroaster (or Zarathustra)** in around 500-600 BCE.

- 2 Their practice is based on the **responsibility of every man and woman to choose between good and evil**, and to respect God's creations.

- 3 The followers of this faith are less than three million in number and are largely concentrated in **Iran**.

- 4 Some followers are also in India where they are referred to as the **Parsis**.

- 5 The teachings of Parsis are contained in their Holy Book **Zend-Avestha**.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

ZOROASTRIANISM



6 The Zoroaster faith believes in a single God or **Ahura Mazda** who is an epitome of just and good behavior.

7 There is a spirit of malice and bad behavior called **Angra Mainyu**.

8 These two spirits keep fighting with each other and this is an eternal struggle and one day good will win over evil and that day will be the last day.

9 Human beings have the choice to follow the good forces or the evil one, but on the **Day of the Judgement**, they have to account for their deeds and will go to heaven or hell depending on their deeds.

10 The Zoroasters' place of worship is the Fire Temple, as **fire is considered to be the Son of Ahura Mazda**.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

ZOROASTRIANISM



- 11** A unique practice of this faith is disposing the dead by **excarnation** (neither by cremation nor by burial).
- 12** It involves placing the dead in circular structures called **Dakhma (tower of silence)** for the corpse to be eaten by vultures. The vultures that eat them are called **Dakhma Nashini**.
- 13** As a religion, Zoroastrianism is among the oldest of religions and their faith also influenced the other religious thoughts, particularly of Christianity as seen from the teachings in the Old Testament.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

ZOROASTRIANISM

ZOROASTRIANISM IN INDIA



- 1 Due to persecution of Zoroasters in the 7th and 8th century CE, pursuant to Arab conquest of Islam, there was a migration of Zoroasters to India.
- 2 They migrated in the region around Gujarat and are referred to as Parsis.
- 3 They are largely confined to the States of Maharashtra and Gujarat. Today, they are less than 50,000 in number and their population is believed to be dwindling further.

BAHAI FAITH



- 1 This is a monotheistic religion founded by Baha'u'llah in 19th-century Persia.

- 2 They believe in the three cardinal principles:
 - Oneness of mankind
 - Oneness of God
 - Oneness of religion.

- 3 They believed that throughout history the Creator has educated humanity through a series of Divine Manifestations.

- 4 These Manifestations include: Krishna, Buddha, Abraham, Moses, Zoroaster, Jesus and Muhammad.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

BAHAI FAITH



- 5 They believe that in the present age, God has revealed Himself through Bahauallah, whose name means 'The Glory of God'.

- 6 The Bahais work for the removal of prejudices based on caste, creed, religion, sex, colour, race and language.
- 7 They advocate **universal education** and the inculcation of a **scientific outlook** among people.
- 8 The Bahais do not believe in superstitions, ceremonies, rituals and dogmas.
- 9 They pray to the one true God, the Creator of the universe. The act of praying is described as '**a conversation with God**'.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

BAHAI FAITH

LOTUS TEMPLE OF BAHAI FAITH



- 1 The **Bahai House of Worship at New Delhi** is popularly known as the Lotus Temple.
- 2 There is no clergy in the temple, no idols, no pictures, no sermons, no rituals. It is a place for communication between man and his Creator, God.
- 3 The shrine has been designed by a young architect, **Mr. Fariburz Sabha**, a Canadian citizen and a Bahai of Iranian descent.

JUDAISM

The Ten Commandments

- I. I am the LORD your God:
you shall not have strange Gods before me.
- II. You shall not take the name of the LORD
your God in vain.
- III. Remember to keep holy the LORD'S Day
- IV. Honor your father and your mother.
- V. You shall not kill.
- VI. You shall not commit adultery.
- VII. You shall not steal.
- VIII. You shall not bear false witness against
your neighbor.
- IX. You shall not covet your neighbor's wife.
- X. You shall not covet your neighbor's goods.

- 1 Judaism is an ancient monotheistic religion which is nearly 3000 (or more) years old.
- 2 It believes in the unity and oneness of the universal creator.
- 3 It traces its origin to the **Abrahamic religion** of the Middle East which also influenced **the religious thought of Christianity, and later Islam.**
- 4 However, Judaism in the present form owes its origin to teachings as revealed to **Moses by God on Mount Sinai, referred to as the Ten Commandments.**
- 5 Today there are 14-15 million followers of Judaism, mostly in Israel.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

JUDAISM

JEWISH FAITH AND SALIENT ASPECTS OF RELIGION



- 1 As a monotheistic religion, Judaism believes in only one God called **Yahweh**.

- 2 Its basic tenets of faith are based on the **Ten Commandments** which are considered the Word of God and are sacrosanct.

- 3 The **Torah** is the religious text of the Jewish people which is also a part of the larger text called Tanakh or the Hebrew Bible.

- 4 The Jews also believe in the concept of the **Day of Judgment**, when the world comes to an end and when everybody will be answerable for one's deeds.

- 5 The Jewish place of worship is called the **Synagogue**.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

JUDAISM

SECTS OF JUDAISM

- 1 There are three main sects of Judaism – the **Orthodox Judaism**, the **Conservative Judaism** and the **Reform Judaism**.
- 2 The Orthodox Judaism believes that Torah and Jewish laws are divine and must be followed. They adhere to all ancient customs, religious practices and traditions.
- 3 The **Reform and Conservative Judaism** are more liberal than Orthodox Judaism.
- 4 The Conservative Judaism follows a more traditional path than the Reform Judaism. They follow a middle path, i.e., they are conservative about some traditional aspects but are more relaxed about other things.
- 5 The Reform Judaism have changed their religious ceremonies and rituals to adapt to the recent times.

RELIGIONS IN MODERN INDIA

JUDAISM

JUDAISM IN INDIA

Jews are believed to be in India for nearly 2500 years. These include five sects of Jews which are :

- **The Cochin Jews** – They are the Malayalam speaking population
- The **Bene Israel (or Children of Israel)** are the most numerous. These are Marathi speaking Jews.
- **The Baghdadis** are Jews who came to India from Baghdad nearly 250 years ago and settled around Mumbai and Pune.

- **The Bene Menashe** – They also known as Manipuri Jews. They live in the border of India and Myanmar. They claim to be the descendants of one of the 10 tribes of the Jews.
- **Bene Ephraim** is a small community of Telugu speaking Jews (Telugu Jews) who converted to Judaism in the 1980s.

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suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

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G. V. Rao

K. Srikanth

D. Sunil Kumar

L. V. Krishna

Y. Deepthi

Amrita Naidu

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